

It's **P****L****A****Y** time

Starved for activity on a rainy afternoon? Learn to party with your PDA

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Feel like a movie or maybe a round of *Quake*? Or perhaps you just feel like relaxing on a quiet evening, with music playing in the background. Then what are you waiting for? Your dream partner, the PDA can do this with ease. So give it a break from all those e-books and word files and party it out with your PDA.

Music, video and games?

Yes, most of the PDAs available (Pocket PCs and Palms) can playback MP3 and video. Pocket PCs have an edge over Palms at present due to their higher memory and audio-video capabilities.

The hardware and display capabilities of most Palm PDAs are usually low, which retards its multimedia capabilities. After all, who would want to watch videos in shades of grey? This limitation of Palm PDAs had given Pocket PCs an unfair advantage when it came to music and video playback. But the balance is shifting with the introduction of high-end Palm powered PDAs such as the Sony Clie series and the Palm m505.

However, it's a different story with playing games as most of the popular games are available in Pocket PC and Palm versions. Now let's see how we can make a PDA sing and dance!

Let it rock

Grooving with the Pocket PC is easier than you'd have thought. Simply copy the MP3 file into your handheld using ActiveSync, which will also convert the MP3 file into a form that the Pocket PC can use. A tap on the file in your Pocket PC is all it takes to play the file in Windows Media Player.

If you are one of the lucky ones with a Sony Clie, music playback should not be a problem for you. Another Palm model with very good audio output is the Handera 330, which comes with an inbuilt microphone, 240x320 QVGA screen, and amplified speakers.

Sorry to disappoint you if you have one of the older Palm models as most of them cannot play MP3s. They need hardware add-ons for multimedia capability to be included. However, the cost of these add-ons is usually comparable and sometimes even less than that of a standard Pocket PC.

Going to the movies

Most Pocket PCs come with Windows Media Player as standard, which allows playback of MP3s only. For playing video files you need Windows Media Player 7.1.

Copy a media file (in .wmv format) into the Pocket PC using ActiveSync. In case you do not have files in the required format, you can use Windows Media Encoder 7.1 to convert them to Pocket PC supported formats. Windows Media Encoder can convert files with .wav, .wma, .wmv, .asf, .avi, .mpg, .mp3, and .bmp extensions. It is available as a free download from the Microsoft site (<http://www.microsoft.com/windows/windowsmedia/en/download/default.asp?pcode=2#location2>). Make sure that you select the Player for the Pocket PC before downloading it.

Transferring the file to your Pocket PC may take a little time if you are not using a USB port. After the transfer is over, play the file by clicking on it. Sometimes it may not play if there is no file association. In this case, open the file from the media player.

If playback is still a problem, go to **Tools >**

